

Personal details and date of CV

- **Surname:** Liu
- **First names:** Zhuchenyang
- **Researcher ID (ORCID):** [0009-0003-5034-2551](#)
- **Links:** [LinkedIn Profile](#)
- **Date of CV:** October 4, 2026

Degree

- **2025-06-18: Master of Science in Data Science (Dual Degree)**
 - KTH Royal Institute of Technology (Sweden) & Aalto University (Finland) (EIT Digital Master School).
 - *Major:* Data Science. GPA: 4.56/5.0, Pass with Honours.
 - Achieved maximum grades in all technical courses.
- **2023-06: Bachelor of Science**
 - Jiangxi University of Finance and Economics (China).
 - *Major:* Data Science and Big Data Technology.

Current employment

- **2025-09 – Present: Doctoral Researcher (Fixed-term)**
 - **Employer:** Aalto University, Department of Information and Communications Engineering, Espoo, Finland.
 - **Supervisor:** Prof. Yu Xiao.
 - **Dissertation Topic:** Toward Efficient Visual Document Retrieval with Index Compression and Model Distillation.
 - **Doctoral progress:** Passed the mid-term review on 02.10.2026 (PhD Candidate). Expected graduation: Q4 2027.
 - **Key Project (AiWo):** Lead Researcher for NLP and Instruction Generation, collaborating with Finnish industrial partners. Designed a decoupled Multimodal Retrieval-Augmented Generation (Visual RAG) framework using ColPali. Successfully implemented an end-to-end local prototype for indexing and inference.
 - **Stage of academic research career:** Stage I (Doctoral Candidate).

Previous work experience

- **2025-02 – 2025-08: Master Thesis Intern**
 - **Employer:** ABB Corporate Research, Västerås, Sweden.
 - *Description:* Developed "AcademicRAG", a Graph-based RAG framework. Proposed a novel clues-based retrieval algorithm utilizing Knowledge Graphs and LLMs, outperforming SOTA baselines in academic Q&A benchmarks.
- **2022-06 – 2022-08: System Architecture Intern**
 - **Employer:** Whale Cloud Technology Co., Ltd, China.
 - *Description:* Assisted in designing high-level architecture for multimodal search functions in a smart city intelligent system.

Research output

Publications

- **1. Liu, Z., Zhang, Y. & Xiao, Y. (2026).** *NanoVDR: Distilling a 2B Vision-Language Retriever into a 70M Text-Only Encoder for Visual Document Retrieval.* arXiv preprint arXiv:2603.12824. (Accepted to EMNLP 2026, Main Conference). [[GitHub](#)] [[HuggingFace](#)]

- Role: First author. Proposed an asymmetric distillation framework achieving 95% teacher quality with $32\times$ fewer parameters.
- **2. Liu, Z., Hu, Z., Zhang, Y. & Xiao, Y. (2026).** *Structural Anchor Pruning: Training-Free Multi-Vector Compression for Visual Document Retrieval*. arXiv preprint arXiv:2601.20107. (Accepted to EMNLP 2026, Main Conference). [[GitHub](#)]
 - Role: First author. Conceived the structural anchor pruning method to optimize Visual RAG indexing efficiency.
- **3. Liu, Z., Wang, Z., Zhang, Y. & Xiao, Y. (2026).** *DistilVDR: A Compact End-to-End Visual Document Retriever via Dual-Student Distillation*. arXiv preprint arXiv:2608.10636. (Accepted to DocInsights 2026: Workshop on Document Intelligence and Understanding, co-located with EMNLP 2026, Budapest, Hungary). [[GitHub](#)] [[HuggingFace](#)]
 - Role: First author. Distilled a 524M end-to-end retriever from an 8B teacher, retaining $\sim 87\%$ quality with a $15\times$ smaller index.
- **4. Liu, Z., Wang, Z., Zhang, Y. & Xiao, Y. (2026).** *ColNanoVDR: Document-Free Query Distillation for Multi-Vector Visual Document Retrieval via Optimal Transport*. arXiv preprint arXiv:2609.34899. (Under Review). [[GitHub](#)] [[Demo](#)] [[Models](#)]
 - Role: First author. Proposed document-free query distillation via optimal transport, retaining $\sim 95\%$ teacher quality at $26\times$ faster query encoding.
- **5. Liu, Z., Zhang, Y. & Xiao, Y. (2026).** *Evidence Attribution in Visual Document Understanding without Coordinates or Region Labels*. arXiv preprint arXiv:2607.24651. (Under Review). [[GitHub](#)]
 - Role: First author. Proposed a language-cue attribution interface (quote-and-retrieve) and identified coordinate output, not localization ability, as the grounding bottleneck.
- **6. Liu, Z., Zhang, Y. & Xiao, Y. (2026).** *IKEA-Bench: Benchmarking and Mechanistic Analysis of Vision-Language Models for Cross-Depiction Assembly Instruction Alignment*. arXiv preprint arXiv:2604.00913. (Under Review). [[Project Page](#)]
 - Role: First author. Constructed the benchmark and conducted the three-layer mechanistic analysis of VLMs.
- **7. Liu, Z., Zhang, Y., He, Y., Paasio, H., Li, C., Semjonova, G. & Xiao, Y. (2026).** *Exploring Human-AI Collaboration in E-Textile Design: A Case Study on Flex Sensor Placement for Shoulder Motion Detection*. Proceedings of the ACM on Human-Computer Interaction, Vol. 10, No. EICS, Article EICSo19. (Published; oral presentation at EICS 2026, Greece). [doi:10.1145/3816771](https://doi.org/10.1145/3816771)
 - Role: First author. Investigated LLM-assisted sensor placement optimization for e-textile motion capture.
- **8. Zhang, Y., Liu, Z., Ploetz, T. & Xiao, Y. (2026).** *Encoder-Free Human Motion Understanding via Structured Motion Descriptions*. arXiv preprint arXiv:2604.21668. (Under Review).
 - Role: Co-author. Contributed to the structured motion description framework and LLM-based motion reasoning.
- **9. Zhang, Y., Liu, Z., He, Y., Ploetz, T. & Xiao, Y. (2026).** *Fine-grained Motion Retrieval via Joint-Angle Motion Images and Token-Patch Late Interaction*. arXiv preprint arXiv:2603.09930. (Accepted to ACCV 2026).
 - Role: Co-author. Contributed to the late interaction retrieval framework and experimental design.
- **10. Zhang, Y., Liu, Z. & Xiao, Y. (2026).** *LingoMotion: An Interpretable and Unambiguous Symbolic Representation for Human Motion*. In 2026 IEEE International Conference on Pervasive Computing and Communications (PerCom), Work-in-Progress Track. (Accepted).
 - Role: Co-author. Contributed to the design of the symbolic representation framework and experimental validation.
- **11. Liu, Z., Chen, S., Tavallaey, S.S., Heintz, F. & Zea, E. (2025).** *AcademicRAG: A Knowledge*

Graph-Enhanced Framework for Intelligent Academic Resource Discovery. Big Data Analytics & Applications, p.5.

- Role: First author. Led the development of the KG-enhanced RAG framework during Master's thesis at ABB.
- **12. Liu, Z.** (2022). *User Adoption Analysis of Social Media Applications Based on NLP and Technology Acceptance Model*. 2022 5th International Conference on Data Science and Information Technology (IEEE-DSIT).
 - Role: Sole author.

Other research outputs

- **Benchmark contributions (MTEB):** Contributed model integrations and evaluation results to the [Massive Text Embedding Benchmark \(MTEB\)](#): added NanoVDR-S-Multi, including a custom asymmetric encoder interface for visual document retrieval, and the ColNanoVDR late-interaction query towers, together with their ViDoRe v1/v2/v3 results on the public leaderboard. Four merged pull requests across [embeddings-benchmark/mteb](#) and [embeddings-benchmark/results](#) (2026).
- **Software/Tool: AcademicRAG (GitHub)** - A comprehensive framework integrating Knowledge Graphs with RAG for academic literature retrieval.

Awards and honours

- **2025: Kaggle Competitions Master**
 - Awarded the [Master tier](#) (Ranked top 0.5% of the global data science community) for consistent high-performance in international machine learning competitions.
 - *Granting body*: Kaggle (Google).
- **2023: Overseas Study Scholarship for Outstanding Undergraduates**
 - Awarded for academic excellence during Bachelor's studies.
 - *Granting body*: Jiangxi University of Finance and Economics.

Other expertise of relevance

- **Technical Skills:**
 - *Core*: Python (PyTorch), LLM Fine-tuning, RAG Pipelines, Knowledge Graphs.
 - *Tools*: Docker, Git, Linux, HuggingFace Ecosystem.